The Affair at 7, Rue de M --

By John Steinbeck

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: Actor 1: Father, Gum
Actor 2: Narrator, John, Gum

FATHER: *(to audience)* At the beginning of the summer I carried my family to Paris and took up residence in a pretty little house at 7, rue de M-, a pretty little converted stable with three floors of rooms above a well-paved courtyard. This was when the events I am about to chronicle were ushered in.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 2: *(In true Twilight Zone/Rod Sterling fashion) (Actor 1 provides ominous background music) It is a dimension as vast as space and as timeless as infinity. It is the middle ground between light and shadow, between science and superstition, and it lies between the pit of man's fears and the summit of his knowledge.*

ACTOR 1: *And in this middle ground is gum! (Actor 2 screams)*

ACTOR 2: *The affair at 7, Rue de M by John Steinbeck*

FATHER: *(to audience)* I can find no alternative to placing the blame on my son John who has only recently attained his eighth year, a lively child of singular beauty and buck teeth. *(John smiles and picks his nose)*

NARRATOR: The young man has become an aficionado of that curious American practice, the chewing of bubble gum, [thank goodness] John had neglected to bring any of the atrocious substance with him from America.

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FATHER: *(to audience)* The child's speech became clear and unobstructed and the hypnotized look went out of his eyes. Alas, this delightful situation was not long to continue.

NARRATOR: An old family friend traveling in Europe brought as a present to the children a more than adequate supply of this beastly gum, thinking to do them a kindness. Thereupon the old familiar situation reasserted itself. Speech fought its damp way past a huge wad of gum and emerged with the sound of a faulty water trap. The jaws were in constant motion, giving the face a look of agony while the eyes took on a glaze like those of a pig with a recently severed jugular.

FATHER: *(to audience)* Since I do not believe in inhibiting my children I resigned myself to a summer not quite so pleasant as I had at first hoped. *(Beat while John chews disgustingly; Father is distracted then refocuses on his story)* On occasion, when I am composing the material for a book or play, in a word, when the utmost of concentration is required, I establish tyrannical rules for my own comfort and effectiveness. One of these rules is that there shall be neither chewing nor bubbling while I am trying to concentrate.

NARRATOR: The rule is so thoroughly understood by John that he accepts it as one of the laws of nature and does not either complain or attempt to evade the ruling.

FATHER: *(To audience as John enthusiastically chews the gum)* Two weeks ago in the late afternoon I sat at my desk composing a short essay, when to my astonishment and chagrin I heard the unmistakable soft plopping sound of a bursting balloon of bubble gum *(Johns pops a bubble and reacts in surprise; he continues to chew loudly and without control) (To John, sternly)* You know the rule.

JOHN: *(eyes wide and tear-filled, jaws working rapidly, he blubbers around a huge wad of gum)* I didn't do it!

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FATHER: *(angry)* What do you mean, you didn't do it? I distinctly heard and now I distinctly see.

JOHN: *(moaning)* Oh, sir! I really didn't. I'm not chewing it, sir. It's chewing me!

FATHER: *(to audience)* For a moment I inspected him closely. He is an honest child, only under the greatest pressure of gain permitting himself an untruth. I had the horrible thought that the bubble gum had finally had its way and that my son's reason was tottering.

NARRATOR: If this were so, it were better to tread softly.

FATHER: *(holding out his hand and speaking kindly)* Lay it here.

JOHN: *(trying valiantly to pull the gum from his mouth; he is terrified)* It won't let me go!

FATHER: Open up. *(Father puts his fingers in John's mouth to forcibly remove the gum. A brief struggle ensues. He finally succeeds and he flings the ugly blob onto his desk)*

NARRATOR: *(Actor 1 assumes the characteristics of the gum)* For a moment it seemed to shudder there on the paper and then with an easy slowness it began to undulate, to swell and recede with the exact motion of being chewed. *(John looks at it in disgust and amazement)*

FATHER: *(to audience)* For a long time we watched it while I drove through my mind for some kind of explanation. *(To John)* How long has it been chewing you?

JOHN: *(very sincerely)* Last night before I went to sleep I put it under my pillow. In the night I was awakened to find that it was in my mouth. I again placed it under my pillow and this morning it was again in my mouth, lying very quietly. When, however, I became thoroughly awakened, and I was no longer master of the gum. It had taken its head. I tried to remove it, sir, and could not. You yourself with all of your strength have seen how difficult it was to extract. Oh Daddy, what do you think has happened?

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FATHER: *(Studying the gum intently)* I must think. This is something a little out of the ordinary, and I do not believe it should be passed over without some investigation.

NARRATOR: As [he] spoke, a change came over the gum. It ceased to chew itself and seemed to rest for a while, and then with a flowing movement like those monocellular animals of the order Paramecium, the gum slid across the desk straight in the direction of [his] son.

FATHER: *(to audience)* For a moment I was stricken with astonishment and for an even longer time I failed to discern its intent. *(John pantomimes a response to the gum's movements, seemingly paralyzed in fright)* It dropped to his knee, climbed horribly up his shirt front. Only then did I understand. It was trying to get back into his mouth. *(to the gum)* Stop!

(Father grabs the gum from John's chin, he carries it to the window and hurls it into the street below. John follows his father and watches the gum land in the street. They look at each other and smile, proud that they have solved the problem. As they turn a look of terror crosses both their faces.)

NARRATOR: *(Actor 1 assumes the characteristics of the gum)* Under the door there crept a paper-thin sheet which, once it had entered the room, grew to a gray blob and rested on the rug, pulsing and chewing. After a moment it moved again toward [John].

FATHER: *(to audience – He pantomimes as he narrates growing more and more breathless)* I fought down my panic as I rushed at it. I grabbed it up and flung it on my desk, then seizing an African war club from among the trophies on the wall, a dreadful instrument studded with brass, I beat the gum. *(He pauses and reacts to the images described in the following narration)*

NARRATOR: The moment [he] rested, it drew itself together and for a few moments chewed very rapidly as though it chuckled, and then inexorably it moved toward [John]. For two weeks [they] were beseiged by the monster.

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FATHER: In exhaustion, with my will to fight back sapped, and after we had tried every possible method to lose or destroy the bubble gum, I placed it at last under a bell jar. I collapsed in a chair to gaze at it with weary defeated eyes.

NARRATOR: *(Actor 1 assumes the characteristics of the gum)* Inside the bell jar the gray tumorous lump moved restlessly about searching for some means of exit from its prison. Now and then it paused as in thought and emitted a bubble.

FATHER: I could feel the hatred it had for me. What does it think?

NARRATOR: What does it want?

FATHER: What does it need? . . . . It needs and wants to get back to its host, my son. It wants to be chewed. *(snaps his fingers at he realizes the solution)* It must be chewed to survive. I had the answer!

NARRATOR: Inside the bell jar the gum inserted a thin wedge of itself under the heavy glass foot and constricted so that the whole jar lifted a fraction of an inch.

FATHER: *(He pantomimes as he speaks)* In the dining room I procured a clear plastic plate. Then turning the bell jar over and securing the monster in its bottom, I smeared the mouth of it with a heavy plastic cement guaranteed to be water-alcohol- and acid-proof. I forced the plate over the opening and pressed it down until the glue took hold and bound the plate to the glass, making an airtight container. And last I turned the jar upright again and adjusted the reading light so that I could observe every movement of my prisoner. I have you, my beauty. I have you at last!

NARRATOR: That was a week ago. *(Actor 2 assumes the characteristics of the gum ast Father watches in amusement: Tries to escape, becomes agitated and nervous; chews itself frantically).*

FATHER: On the fourth day it began to weaken and I observed with joy a kind of dryness on its once slick and shiny exterior.

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NARRATOR: It is almost over. *(Actor 2 assumes the characteristics of the dying gum: lies quietly, heaves, sighs as Father watches solemnly)*

FATHER: Its color has turned to a nasty yellow. *(turns his back on the gum and speaks to the audience)* It will die tonight *(as Father speaks, Actor 2, as the gum gathers itself and looms menacingly behind Father, then grins and shakes its gummy head)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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